Why dbt Is Taking Over the Data World

(in 4 minutes)

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dbt isn't just another passing fad—it's become a go-to solution for SQL-based data transformations.

#1 What Exactly Is dbt?

- A CLI tool that lets you transform data using SQL (and Jinja).

- It's not an engine (like Spark) or a database (like Postgres/Snowflake).

- It manages your SQL transformations inside your warehouse, making version control, testing, and documentation a breeze.

#2 dbt Concepts 101

- Models: Core of dbt. Each model is a .sql file that transforms data into tables or views in your warehouse.

- Compiler + Runner: dbt compiles your SQL + Jinja, then executes it on Snowflake, BigQuery, Databricks, etc.—it never moves your actual data.

- Jinja Templating: Reference existing tables with source() and other dbt models with ref() to form end-to-end transformation lineage.

- Testing & Docs: Quickly test models, auto-generate documentation, and version-control everything with Git—like real software.

#3 Why Was It Created?

- Founder Tristan Handy wanted to empower data analysts to own their transformations.

- dbt brings software engineering best practices (e.g., modular code, CI/CD, version control) to SQL-based pipelines.

- dbt democratizes data transformation by enabling analysts to write and manage SQL scripts themselves—no need to wait for engineering for every change.

#4 What Makes It So Popular?

- Hit the market fit

- Performance Expectancy: It consolidates how teams write, test, and document SQL.

- Effort Expectancy: If you know SQL, dbt is easy to learn—no hefty setup required.

- Social Influence: The growing adoption of dbt within the data community and endorsements from reputable organizations.

- Facilitating Conditions: Minimal prerequisites—just your warehouse, an IDE, and a willingness to write SQL.

My mom read my articles to support her son. Now, she can design a data architecture and write ETL scripts.

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